NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER

VOLUME I

The Outcast of Ashenveil

Where shadow breathes and storm winds cry,
Where outcast hands may touch the sky,
Where ancient towers hold their breath
And every trial tastes of death --
There walks the boy the village spurned,
Who carries more than he has learned.

Age Rating: 15+ | Dark Epic Fantasy | First Edition

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FOREWORD

The World of Ashenveil

Before you enter this story, you must understand the land that holds it. Ashenveil is not a great city. It is not a fortress or a seat of power. It is a village -- old, stubborn, and quietly afraid. It sits at the meeting point of three forests: the Thornwood to the east, a dense and briar-choked woodland where hunters go and sometimes do not return; the Greymantle to the north, a pale and foggy expanse whose trees grow white and whose birds never sing; and the Deepreach to the west, the oldest forest in all the known lands, older than the kingdoms, older than written memory, so dark and so vast that even the most seasoned rangers mark its edges on their maps and write simply: Here ends the known world.

Ashenveil has one great protection: the ward. A shimmering forcefield of elemental energy, woven over generations by five anchors -- five people of power bound to the village by blood and oath. The five elements required are earth, water, air, fire, and shadow. For years, the ward held firm. But the fifth anchor -- the shadow anchor -- has been missing for decades. The forcefield has been incomplete. And something in the Deepreach has noticed the gap.

Magic in this world is elemental and personal. Every individual with power has a unique relationship with their element -- it is not simply a tool but an extension of identity. Shadow magic is the rarest and most feared. Air magic is free and wild. Earth is patient. Water heals and drowns in equal measure. Fire remembers everything it burns. And above all of these, there is the Void -- and those who have touched it are never quite the same again.

Beyond Ashenveil lie other kingdoms, other realms, other peoples. The Kingdom of Vieau to the south, built on the principle that solidarity is strength. The Shattered Archipelago to the far south, whose islands were once one continent. The High Plateau of Vel, where storms never stop. And beyond all of that, at the very edge of dimensional stability, the Void -- the space between worlds where something old and terrible has been growing in the dark for a very long time. Its name is Dimitreus. It was not always a void entity. It was once a man.

This is the world into which Nicholas Shadowrider was born. An outcast, a boy with two elements in a village that fears one of them, carrying a pact he did not ask for and a destiny he does not yet know is his. The story begins simply -- with a boy walking to the well, feeling the ward tremble, and seeing something in the water that should not be there. It ends very differently.

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

The Cast of Volume I

NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER

Half-Elven Warlock -- Protagonist

Shadow and Air/Wind. Storm-caller. Empathic -- feels the emotions of others before they consciously form. Bound by an inherited warlock pact. The missing fifth anchor of the Ashenveil ward.

ALEXA

Shadow-Beast -- Core Companion

Travels as a small winged dog, white with shadow-tipped fur. In battle: massive armoured shadow-beast with storm-charged claws. Bonded to Nicholas completely.

VALYREN

Chainborn -- Champion

Blood Dominion: cuts his own flesh to borrow any elemental essence. Twin blades Fang and Talon. Living chains. No drawbacks, no cooldowns.

ADELAIDE

Human -- Healer

Light law magic, calm aura, staff-blade. Always with Dianne.

DIANNE

Human -- Heartfire

Heartfire aura counters fear and despair. Magical restorative food. Never a fighter. Always with Adelaide.

ROMINAE

Half-Demon -- Dark Witch

Dark arcane magic, shadow hexes, soul-sight, dimensional pockets. Morally complex. Arrives without announcement.

YULIOH

Human -- Law Paladin

Tower shields of law energy. Binding judgements. Defensive anchor of the group.

JULY

Half-Fae -- Light Druid

Speaks to ancient living things. Nature and light healing. Bloom surges. Feels the age of forests physically.

KSU

Inkborn -- Paint Mage

Her body produces living magical ink. Drawn fire burns, drawn stone stands, drawn creatures move. Ten active sigils maximum.

LAURA

Human -- Sound Sovereign / Battle DJ

Frequency blasts, rhythm shields, vocal hypnosis, tempo manipulation. Floating enchanted DJ setup. Microphone that amplifies power tenfold. Strategic mind of the group.

PROLITH

Unknown -- Enchanter

Male. Pale, jet-black hair with crimson sheen, spiral grey eyes. Appears ONLY when Nicholas is alone. The Whisperwand. Scent of burning roses. Three sigils = full access to Nicholas's mind.

VLAEDRYN

Unknown -- Betrayal Lover

Raven hair, amber-red eyes, fire veins. Emberfang Blade. Velvet Voice, Gaze of Surrender, Dream Intrusion. A dark thread runs through him.

ALEA

Human -- Earth Warden

Nicholas's mother. Terrain shaping, thorns, ward anchor.

ROHMANA

Unknown -- Oracle

Appears at turning points only. Fractured future-sight.

BUNBUN

Unknown -- Artifact Shopkeeper

Unique one-of-a-kind items. Knows more than they let on.

DIMITREUS

Void Entity -- The Great Enemy

Was human. Now assembles himself in the void. Watching. Patient. Inevitable.

PROLOGUE

A Watching from the Void

Between the worlds there is a place with no name, no light, no sound. He has lived there long enough that he no longer misses those things.

There was a space between the worlds. It had no name because no language belonging to the living had ever needed to describe it. It existed in the negative -- the gap between one reality and the next, the pause between heartbeats, the silence after thunder stops but before the next bolt decides to fall. It was made of the absence of things. And in that absence, something was building.

Dimitreus stood -- if standing was the right word for what he did in a place without ground -- at the centre of nothing, and he watched. Watching was what he did now. It was patience, and patience was power, and he had learned the shape of power from the inside out by losing it completely and spending two decades clawing it back piece by piece from the bones of the void.

The ward was failing. He could see it the way you could see a candle through a dirty window -- the light dimmer than it should be, guttering, the flame bending in a draft that should not be there. The forcefield around Ashenveil had held for sixty years on the strength of four anchors. Four was not enough. Four was never enough.

He could not move against it directly -- not yet. The four remaining anchors still held. Alea with her earth-staff and her thorns. Tamera with her chain-wrapped fists and her iron patience. Maria singing her water-tides in the mornings. Old Nichola at his gravity posts. Four anchors holding a five-anchor ward. It was like watching four people try to carry a table meant for eight. They could do it. But they were tired.

He turned his attention toward a specific house on a specific lane. Toward a boy who walked with his head down and his shadow slightly wrong. The shadow moved a half-second after the boy did. Most people did not notice that. Dimitreus noticed. Dimitreus looked at everything.

The boy was the fifth anchor. Shadow and air. A warlock pact sealed in the generation before. Elements the village feared because the village feared everything it did not understand. The boy would either become the thing that saved Ashenveil or the thing that destroyed it. Dimitreus found both outcomes acceptable. He settled deeper into the nothing and continued to watch.

-- * --

In the village of Ashenveil, a boy named Nicholas was walking to the well. He did not know he was being watched. He did not know what was coming. He did not know what he was. Not yet.

CHAPTER I

The Boy the Village Forgot

An outcast is not someone who was rejected. An outcast is someone who was seen clearly -- and the ones who saw them were afraid.

-- From the Codex of Ashenveil, Third Reckoning

Nicholas Shadowrider was seventeen years old and had learned to walk as if he was not quite there. It was a skill that took years to perfect. The trick was in the shoulders -- keep them slightly curved, never squared, never claiming space. The eyes stayed down or mid-distance, never meeting. The footfalls were light, deliberate, the pace of someone moving through a room full of sleeping animals. He had started learning it at nine when the first stone was thrown. He had completed it by twelve when the stones stopped and the silence replaced them, which was worse.

Silence was organised. Silence was a decision. A stone thrown in anger was personal -- a flash of fear given kinetic shape. But silence was the whole village deciding, collectively and quietly, that Nicholas Shadowrider would not be addressed unless absolutely necessary, and that the gap he walked through when he moved between buildings was not truly a gap but rather a space that belonged to something they preferred not to name.

He understood it. That was the worst part. He had turned it over in his mind enough times that he had excavated every component of it, and he understood it. His shadow was wrong. Not wrong in a dramatic way -- not writhing, not speaking, not growing claws. Just wrong. It fell slightly behind him. It moved in the same direction he moved but with a delay -- sometimes half a second, sometimes a full second, long enough that if you watched carefully you would notice it and then feel, at the base of your spine, something cold and quiet that your body identified as danger before your mind had caught up.

~ * ~

The well was in the centre square. It was old -- older than most of the buildings around it, older than the ward, possibly older than the village itself. The stones were a darker grey-blue that the scholars called sea-stone though the nearest sea was three days of hard riding away.

He came through the square from the narrow lane between the chandler's and the seamstress's workroom, his bucket in one hand, and found the square occupied. Seven people. Elder Corvin standing near the well as if he had been positioned there. Herath the blacksmith. His wife, Dorn. The Cavins family.

Nicholas kept walking. He reached the well. He set his bucket down. He began to lower the rope. Elder Corvin said nothing. The silence was so complete that Nicholas could hear the rope paying out against the old wooden winch, the small squeak of the mechanism.

It was Tessa who made the mistake of looking at his shadow. He heard the small, involuntary sound she made -- not quite a word, more like the beginning of one that she stopped.

"The mist was closer last night," Corvin said. Not to Nicholas. To the air.

Nicholas drew up his second bucket.

"Three fingers of ground past the first marker stones," Herath said. "Checked it myself at dawn."

"The ward should hold," Dorn said.

"The ward held better when there were five anchors," Corvin said, and this time there was a direction to it. A slight inclination of his face toward Nicholas that was not quite looking at him and not quite not.

Nicholas filled his bucket. He coiled the well rope back on its hook with the same care he always used. He picked up his bucket. He walked away. He did not let his hands shake until he was back in the lane between the chandler and the seamstress, and then only slightly, and only for a moment.

~ * ~

The house Nicholas shared with his mother was on the far western lane -- the lane closest to the Deepreach. Alea was at the long table, working through a set of dried

root bundles with a bone-handled knife and a methodical patience that she applied to all physical tasks.

"The mist was closer," Nicholas said, setting the water bucket on the kitchen shelf.

Alea set down her knife. "I felt it. Since before dawn."

"Elder Corvin was at the well."

"Yes." She returned to her cutting.

"He said the ward held better with five anchors."

"He says that often."

"In my direction."

Alea looked at her son with eyes that were the same brown-grey as his -- slightly too deep-set, slightly too watchful. "Nicholas. You were the fifth anchor before you were born. The pact was sealed. You were always going to carry that. I cannot fix what the village makes of it."

"You could tell them."

"I have told them. Your grandmother has told them. Your grandfather has told them twice in formal council." Her knife moved steadily. "People hear what they are ready to hear."

Nicholas stood at the window and looked west at the dark mass of the Deepreach on the horizon. "Something is coming from it," he said.

"Yes."

"You know what it is?"

"Something that wants the ward to fail. Something that has been testing it for months. I think it knows about the gap." She set down her knife. "Then we should do something about it. But becoming the fifth anchor requires a trial. It requires your power coming fully forward."

"They already fear it."

"Fearing a shadow that moves wrong is different from watching it storm." He had no answer for that. He turned back to the window. The dark tree line did not move. But the mist -- thin, grey-blue, low to the ground -- crept another inch forward across the scrubland while he watched.

~ * ~

That evening Nicholas went to the back garden and sat on the old stone bench his grandfather had built and looked at the Deepreach. He felt it all the time. That was the thing nobody in Ashenveil understood and that he had never tried to explain.

He felt everything. Not in a metaphorical sense -- not simply that he was more emotionally sensitive than average. It was physical. When he was in a crowd, the emotions of the people around him pressed against him like heat, like pressure. Elder Corvin's contempt was a cold, heavy thing that sat on his chest. Tessa Cavin's guilt-adjacent discomfort was a different kind of weight, sharper, more pointed, located somewhere behind his sternum. Herath the blacksmith was almost always in a low-grade irritation that tasted, in Nicholas's empathic vocabulary, like iron filings.

He had learned to keep his face still regardless of what he was absorbing. Out here, alone, he let the stillness go. The forest had a feeling -- a vast, slow, ancient patience. But lately the patience had a layer under it. Something urgent. Something that had been waiting a very long time and had recently decided that the waiting was almost over.

He put his hand down onto the stone of the bench and let a little of the other thing out -- the wind thing, the air thing, the power that lived in his chest alongside the shadow. A small breeze moved through the still garden, circling once around the apple tree, lifting three leaves and letting them spiral down. He pulled it back in. He sat alone in the dark garden until his mother called him for dinner.

CHAPTER II

Smoke at the Edge of Thornwood

The Deepreach does not attack. It simply remembers -- and when the things inside it stir, it is because they have remembered something they wish had stayed forgotten.

-- Ranger Dispatch, Northern Ashenveil Reach, Year 847

The mist came to the marker stones three days later. Not because it had been repelled -- the mist had gathered the information it came for. It knew the gap. It knew the shape of the missing anchor. It would come back with that knowledge.

The four anchors reinforced the ward every dawn. By the fourth day, even Tamera -- who had the most physical endurance of any person Nicholas knew and who treated exhaustion as a personal insult -- was eating double portions and sleeping ten hours instead of her customary six.

Three things happened in the following week. The first: more mist. Each morning, closer by a measured fraction. Testing. Learning. The second: the animals began to behave strangely. The birds in the transitional woodland stopped singing and relocated. The dogs in Ashenveil became restless and could not be calmed. Even the chickens refused to face west. The third thing was the dream. Nicholas dreamed the same dream four nights in a row.

In the dream he was standing at the well in the centre square, but the well was different -- larger, older, the water below not clear but dark and perfectly still. He was alone. He looked into the dark water. Something looked back.

Not Dimitreus -- he did not know Dimitreus yet. Something else. Something that wore different faces on different nights. On the fourth night simply a mirror image of himself, exact and perfect except that the reflection's shadow did not move wrong. It moved right. And somehow that was the most frightening version.

He woke from the fourth dream at three in the morning with his hands clenched and the air in his room moving in slow circles around him and his own shadow stretching toward the window, toward the west, toward the dark forest.

He sat up. He breathed. He let the air go still. He did not sleep again that night.

~ * ~

On the eighth day, he went to BunBun. The shop was on the eastern edge of Ashenveil, past the pump-house, on a lane that most people avoided without being able to articulate exactly why. The interior smelled of old wood, metal oil, and something floral that changed slightly on every visit. BunBun was behind the counter. BunBun was always behind the counter.

BunBun's race and origins were a matter of considerable speculation in Ashenveil, mostly because BunBun was impossible to fit into any single category. They were neither young nor old, neither tall nor short, with eyes that were a very clear amber and a face that said nothing at all about what was happening behind it.

"Nicholas," said BunBun.

"I need something," Nicholas said.

"You always need something. Sit down." There was a stool on the customer's side of the counter. Nicholas sat on it. "The mist is testing the ward," he said. "I know." "My family is exhausted holding four points that are supposed to be five." "I know that too." "I want to do something about it."

BunBun looked at him for a long moment with those clear amber eyes. "Do you know what you are?"

Nicholas considered the question seriously, which was the only way he knew how to consider questions. "I am the fifth anchor. I am a warlock -- or the beginning of one, whatever that means for someone who has never been trained. I have shadow and air in me. I have a pact I did not sign but that is mine anyway."

"That is the technical answer. Do you know what you are?"

Nicholas was quiet for a moment. "No," he said.

"Good." BunBun reached beneath the counter and produced something that they set on the wood between them. "That is the right answer. People who know what they are have stopped looking. You are still looking. That is important."

The object was small -- about the size of a closed fist, made of dark metal with a surface like old water. It was shaped like a compass with eight points instead of

the usual four, and in place of the magnetic needle, a thin shadow-line that moved, slowly, on its own.

"A shadow compass," BunBun said. "It does not point north. It points toward what you need to find." The needle was pointing west. Toward the Deepreach.

"How much?" he said.

"You cannot afford it," BunBun said. "I am giving it to you."

"Why?"

BunBun smiled for the first time. It was a strange smile -- warm and sad and knowing all at once. "Because someone gave it to me when I needed it. And because what is coming from the Deepreach will arrive regardless of whether you are ready for it, and I would rather you have a tool than not."

Nicholas took the compass. The shadow-needle swung once -- a full rotation -- and then settled again, pointing west. "Take care of it," BunBun said. "It is not indestructible." "Neither am I," Nicholas said. "No." BunBun was already moving back to their work. "But you are harder to break than you think."

CHAPTER III

The Forcefield Event

The ward does not break cleanly. It tears. Like old cloth under a new weight -- you hear it before you see it, and by the time you see it, the tear is already wider than it looks.

-- Alea Shadowrider, from her private journal

The forcefield failed on a Tuesday. Not completely. Not catastrophically. It was quieter than that, and in some ways worse for the quietness. Nicholas felt it from inside the house -- a vibration that was not quite sound and not quite feeling but something in between, a shiver along the electromagnetic equivalent of his bones.

He was outside before the thought fully formed. He started toward the southeast marker post at a run and arrived at the same time as his grandfather.

Nichola was seventy-one years old and moved like a man twenty years younger when his power was up. His gravity anchors were already active -- Nicholas could feel them as a kind of compression, a dense focussed weight that pressed the ground down in rings around the marker post. But Nichola's face was tight in a way Nicholas had never seen it before.

"I need more time," Nichola said. Not to Nicholas -- to himself, or to the ward.

"What do you need?" Nicholas said.

His grandfather looked at him. The look was complicated. There was love in it and worry and something that might have been guilt. "I need the fifth anchor," Nichola said.

Nicholas looked at the gap. He could feel it clearly now -- the absence of the shadow-point, the hollow in the ward's structure where the fifth connection should have been. He could feel the shape of what was missing because the shape was his own shape, his own element, his own power. He reached into his chest -- metaphorically but also, somehow, not entirely metaphorically -- and found the thing that had always been there, waiting.

He let it out. Not all of it. Not in a controlled way -- he did not know how to be controlled with it yet, had never been trained, had spent his whole life pressing it down. But he let enough of it out to reach toward the gap the way a person reaches toward a door handle in the dark -- blind, feeling, hoping the shape is right.

The shadow-power met the edge of the ward. It fit. Not perfectly -- the connection was rough, unstable, held together by instinct rather than training. But it held. The gap closed. The mist stopped advancing.

Nichola made a sound that was not quite a word. "Nicholas," he said. And then, more quietly: "Nicholas."

"I know," Nicholas said. He could feel the ward now in a way he had not felt it before -- not just the gap but the whole structure, all five points, the full geometry of it. He could feel his mother to the south, her earth power pressing down through the roots. He could feel his grandmothers. He could feel his grandfather beside him. And in the gap, he felt himself. His own shadow-power, unfamiliar and unsteady, holding.

"The village is going to see this," Nichola said. "I know." "They are going to have questions." "They have always had questions." "Different questions now. Better questions. Maybe." He put his hand on Nicholas's shoulder -- a rare gesture. "You did well."

Nicholas held the gap and said nothing. Behind him, he heard voices in the lane. The village was waking up. People were coming out to look. He kept his back to them and held the ward and let them look.

~ * ~

Elder Corvin came to the house that evening. He arrived at dusk, alone, without his formal robes, and he knocked instead of demanding entry, which was also new. Alea opened the door.

"Corvin," she said.

"Alea." He looked past her to where Nicholas was visible at the table. "I would like to speak with the boy."

"Nicholas," Alea said.

"I heard." Nicholas came to the door but did not step aside. "What do you want to say?"

Corvin looked at him for a long time. The contempt was still there -- Nicholas could feel it -- but something else had moved in front of it. Something that might, in another person in another context, have been respect.

"What you did today," Corvin said, "was necessary."

"Yes."

"I have been... incorrect in my position on your presence here."

Nicholas waited.

"Not wrong," Corvin said, because even this version of the conversation still needed to preserve certain structures. "Incorrect. There is a difference."

"I understand the difference," Nicholas said.

"Good." The elder stood in the doorway for another moment. "The ward held today because of you. I am choosing to let that be the relevant fact going forward." He left.

Nicholas closed the door. Alea was behind him, and when he turned, he could see that she was very carefully not crying, which was a different thing from not wanting to. "Okay?" she said. "Yes," he said. And then: "The compass is still pointing west." "I know. It is going to keep pointing west for a while." "The Deepreach." "The Earth Tower," she said. "There is a tower in the Deepreach. Your grandfather built it -- or helped build it, or activated it, the history is unclear. It is the source of the ward. If it were fully activated, the ward would hold on its own."

Nicholas sat down across from her. "Why has no one activated it?"

Alea looked at the table. "Because the Deepreach is not a place that people enter casually. Because between here and the tower, there are things that test you. Not just in the fighting sense -- though there is fighting. In the fundamental sense. It tests what you are. What you are made of. The fear you will not name."

"And people have failed."

"People have turned back. Some have not come back at all."

Nicholas held the shadow compass. The needle pointed west. "Tell me about the tower," he said.

CHAPTER IV

Powers That Should Not Exist

Shadow is not darkness. Darkness is the absence of light. Shadow is the proof that light exists -- and that something stands between the light and what it would illuminate.

-- From the Warlock Codex, authorship disputed

He practiced at night. The back garden. The stone bench. The apple tree. The dark wall of the Deepreach in the distance. The shadow came easily when he did not fight it. It responded to intention more than technique -- he did not need to know the mechanics, he only needed to want something and reach.

The garden's shadows lengthened when he let them, moving toward him like water flowing toward a drain. He could hold shadow in his hands -- a dark fabric that existed only if he did not look at it directly. The moment he tried to see it clearly, it dissipated. He had to look sideways at it, attention oblique, while his hands maintained the contact.

The air was different. Air came with a kind of joy that shadow did not have. When he reached for wind, the power responded with what felt like eagerness. The wind liked to move. It liked to answer. He could make it circle the garden, pull it through the apple tree's branches, push it outward in a pressure wave that made the leaves shudder.

The combination was the strange part. When he let both out at once -- shadow and air together, not fighting, just coexisting -- something happened that was neither element separately. The air grew darker. And the shadow moved faster, carried by the wind, directional rather than ambient. Storm-shadow, he thought. That is what it is.

He practiced until the moon was high and then sat on the bench and breathed. His hands were dark at the fingertips -- a shadow-dark that faded slowly as he pulled the power back in, like the last light fading from a window at dusk.

"You look better when you let it out," said a voice.

Nicholas was on his feet in an instant, turned, the shadow already rising in his hands before he had thought about reaching for it. The garden was empty. Except it was not.

Standing at the western edge of the garden, between the last row of herb beds and the beginning of the scrubland, was someone he had not heard approach and had not felt approach, which was wrong on both counts -- he felt everyone who came near him. This person had no empathic signal at all.

He was male. Pale as winter stone, with hair so black it had a slight crimson cast where the moonlight caught it. His eyes were grey with a spiral quality -- not spiralling, not moving, but structured like a spiral. He was wearing dark clothes that were somehow very elegant, and he was holding something in his right hand -- a wand, narrow, black, with silver veining that moved slightly as Nicholas looked at it.

And the air smelled of burning roses.

Nicholas held the shadow in his hands and did not release it. "Who are you?" he said.

"Someone who has been watching you practice," the stranger said. His voice was pleasant and low and had a quality that Nicholas catalogued and filed under: be careful. "You have real talent. The shadow-air combination is rare. Most warlocks do not discover it on their own."

"I did not ask about my power. I asked who you are."

"My name is Prolith." He said it simply, as if it explained itself. "I am not a threat to you."

"You have no empathic signal," Nicholas said. "Every person has one. You have none. That is not how people work."

"I am not precisely a person." He smiled -- not unkindly, not reassuringly. The smile of someone being accurate rather than kind. "I am something adjacent to it. A category that does not have a clean name in the current vocabulary."

"What do you want?"

"Currently? To watch you practice. You are interesting. The warlock pact in your bloodline is unusual -- most inherited pacts are dormant by the third

generation. Yours is not only active, it is growing. I am curious about why."

"I am going to go back inside," Nicholas said.

"Of course." Prolith did not move. "I will be here tomorrow if you have questions." "I will not have questions." "You will." Still pleasant, still accurate. "You have a great many questions. You have been keeping them inside because there is no one to ask. But the questions are there. I can hear them."

Nicholas backed toward the house without turning his back on the stranger. "The scent of burning roses," he said. "I will know when you are near."

"I would expect nothing less," Prolith said.

Nicholas went inside. He stood in his bedroom for a long time with his back against the closed door and the smell of roses -- faint, residual -- following him like a second shadow. He did not tell his mother. He should have told his mother. He did not.

CHAPTER V

BunBun and the Shadow Compass

Already told in Chapter II -- this chapter deepens the encounter.

-- The artifact shopkeeper's second conversation with Nicholas, three days later

Three days after his encounter with Prolith, Nicholas returned to BunBun's shop. The green door. The carved wooden sign. The interior smell of old wood and metal oil and something floral. BunBun was behind the counter.

"You came back," BunBun said. "You never come back this quickly."

"I need to ask you something," Nicholas said. He sat on the stool without being invited this time, which was new. BunBun's amber eyes registered this and noted it and said nothing.

"Someone came to my garden at night," Nicholas said. "He gave no empathic signal. He had a wand with silver veining. The air smelled of burning roses before he arrived."

BunBun was quiet for a moment. The quality of the quiet was different from BunBun's usual quality of quiet -- it had a weight to it. "Prolith," they said.

"You know him."

"I know of him." BunBun moved behind the counter, doing something with their hands that might have been arranging things or might have been simply something to do while thinking. "He is an enchanter. A specific kind. The kind that is drawn to pact energy -- to the particular resonance of inherited warlock bloodlines. He will not harm you directly. That is not his method."

"What is his method?"

"Accumulation. Gradual access. Sigils placed without consent that build toward something larger." BunBun looked at him steadily. "Has he placed one on you?"

Nicholas thought about it. He felt the inside of himself the way he felt the inside of rooms -- the empathic texture of things, the quality of what was present and what was absent. There was something. Very small. Located in the centre of his chest, below the shadow-power, below the ward-connection. Something that had not been there before his night encounter. Small and patient and not quite inert.

"Yes," he said quietly. "I think he has."

BunBun nodded, as if this was what they had expected. "Then you should know: three sigils give him access to your consciousness in your most vulnerable moments. You are at one." A pause. "Do not be alone when you can manage it. And tell the people traveling with you. When they arrive."

"When they arrive?" He had not told BunBun about the Deepreach plan, about the compass, about any of it.

BunBun smiled that strange sad knowing smile again. "They are coming, Nicholas. The compass is not pointing at the Deepreach only. It is pointing at what assembles itself around the anchor before the anchor can go to the Deepreach." A pause. "Be ready to open the door."

CHAPTER VI

Alexa

Some bonds do not form. They are discovered -- already complete, already ancient, already inevitable. You do not choose them. You recognise them.

-- Lore of the Shadow-Beasts, collected fragments

She arrived on a Thursday morning in the third week of the mist. Nicholas was at the well when something landed on the edge of it. A dog -- or something shaped like a dog. Small enough to sit on a well's stone edge. White with fur that had darker tips at the paws and ears and tail. Grey eyes with depth in them, the same quality of depth that Nicholas associated with things that were older and more aware than they looked. The dog had wings. Small wings, folded close against its back, feathered in the same shadow-tipped white as its fur. Clearly real. Clearly functional. Clearly just there in the same matter-of-fact way the dog itself was there.

It looked at him. He looked at it. It made no sound. It did not wag its tail. It simply looked at him with those grey eyes and waited, in the manner of someone who had arrived for an appointment and expected to be acknowledged. "You are not a normal dog," Nicholas said. The dog did not disagree.

He reached out slowly and held the back of his hand toward it -- the standard greeting for a dog you were not certain about. It moved its nose forward and touched the back of his hand and then, with the same matter-of-fact certainty, settled its chin on his knuckles and looked up at him.

Nicholas felt something happen. He felt it in his chest, in the empathic layer where other people's feelings lived. But this was not other people's feelings -- this was a bond, a connection, a line of shared feeling running from something that was the dog to something that was himself, thin as a thread but with a tensile strength that he instinctively understood would not break under any ordinary pressure.

She was already bonded to him. Had been, somehow, for longer than this moment. He felt her feelings: recognition, certainty, relief -- the feeling of finding something you have been looking for, the feeling of finally.

"How long have you been looking?" he said. The dog lifted her chin from his knuckles and her tail, which had been still until this moment, moved once -- a single deliberate sweep. Long. Very long.

"All right," Nicholas said. He picked up his water bucket. "Come on, then." She came on.

He named her Alexa because she looked like an Alexa. He did not know why that was true. It simply was.

~ * ~

Alea looked at Alexa for a long time on the first morning and said: "Shadow-beast lineage. Very old. I did not know any of them were still in this region."

"What are they?" Nicholas asked.

"Companions. They do not bond by accident. They bond to people they have recognised. Chosen, maybe. Found." She looked at Alexa with the expression she reserved for things that were important. "Keep her safe."

"She can fight," Nicholas said. He had felt this from the bond -- the combat-quiet, the readiness of a predator.

"Yes," Alea agreed. "She can fight. Keep her safe anyway."

Alexa looked from Alea to Nicholas and then back to Alea with the expression of a creature who understood exactly what was being said and was evaluating the source. Then she went and lay in the patch of morning sun on the kitchen floor and closed her eyes, which seemed to be her position on the matter.

She was like that -- Alexa. Absolutely certain of things. Absolutely uninterested in performing that certainty for anyone. She moved through the village beside Nicholas and the people who had spent seventeen years looking at his shadow sideways now looked at the shadow-beast beside him and felt the same cold quiet at the base of their spines, but doubled. Some of them managed the careful blankness anyway. Most of them stopped trying.

Herath the blacksmith looked at Alexa one morning from across the market lane, and Alexa looked back at him with those grey-depth eyes for a long moment, and then looked away first, which was a choice, which told Herath something that he spent the rest of the day processing. He did not come to the house. But he stopped using the careful blankness after that.

CHAPTER VII

Prolith

The Whisperwand does not compel. It suggests. It makes the suggestion so precisely fitted to what you already want that you cannot tell the difference between the suggestion and your own desire. That is the art of it.

-- From the Records of Enchantment Arts, restricted section, Ashenveil Archive

He came again on the fifth night. Nicholas was in the garden, not practicing -- just sitting, the shadow compass in his hand, watching the Deepreach. He had decided not to go inside until he came, which was the decision of someone who had accepted that the coming was a fact and that avoidance would not improve the situation.

The smell of burning roses arrived first. Then Prolith, at the garden's western edge, the Whisperwand held loosely at his side.

"You waited for me," Prolith said. Something in his voice that might have been pleased.

"I decided that if you were going to come to my garden," Nicholas said, "we were going to have an honest conversation instead of a managed one."

Prolith was quiet for a moment. "All right," he said. "Ask."

"What do you want from me?"

A long pause. Prolith moved to sit on the low stone wall at the garden's edge -- not invasive, maintaining distance, the movement of someone doing something that was meant to be non-threatening. "The warlock pact in your bloodline," he said. "I have been studying pact energy for thirty years. Most inherited pacts are dormant by the third generation. Yours is not only active, it is at full intensity, and it is growing. I have not seen that before. I want to understand it."

"And the sigil," Nicholas said. "The one you placed on me. The one I can feel in the centre of my chest."

Prolith was very still. "You can feel it," he said.

"I am empathic. I feel foreign things inside me. I have been feeling that sigil since the night you first came."

Something moved across Prolith's face. "That is not a standard ability," he said. "Sigils are not usually detectable without specific training in counter-enchantment work."

"I am a warlock who has never had training and has spent seventeen years feeling everything in a village full of people who were afraid of him. I am very good at identifying what does not belong." Nicholas looked at him steadily. "Remove it. Or we are done talking and I begin telling the people around me exactly what you are."

Prolith looked at the Whisperwand. At Nicholas. At the Whisperwand again. Then he made a motion with the wand -- small, precise, the motion of someone doing something that cost them something -- and the foreign sensation in Nicholas's chest dissolved. Gone.

Nicholas breathed. "Thank you," he said.

"You are not what I expected," Prolith said quietly.

"No," Nicholas agreed. "I rarely am." A pause. "You can come back. If you want to talk, you can come back. But the sigil approach is closed. Permanently."

"Understood," Prolith said. He stood from the wall. The Whisperwand was still. "I will be honest with you about something, since you have been honest with me. I know the history of the pact in your bloodline. The full history -- the original compact, the names of the people who held it before you, what it was sealed against."

Nicholas went very still. "What do you mean, what it was sealed against?"

"Not tonight," Prolith said. "When there is more trust between us. When you have decided whether I am something worth trusting." He turned toward the scrubland, toward the Deepreach's dark edge. "The scent of burning roses will still precede me. I will not come without it."

He went. Nicholas sat in the garden for a long time after, the shadow compass heavy in his hand.

CHAPTER VIII

Companions Gathering

The right people do not appear because you need them. They appear because the world has been moving them toward you for a long time, and the moment arrives when the geometry is right.

-- From the Lore of the Wandering Paths

They began arriving the week after the forcefield event. Nicholas did not send for them. He would not have known where to send. They came because the word had moved -- through the ranger networks, through the trade roads, through whatever communication system exists among people who know that certain events in certain places are beginning points rather than endings.

Valyren arrived first. He was taller than average, lean in the way that very good fighters were lean -- functional, nothing wasted. Dark brown skin and close-cut hair and the Chainborn veins faintly visible on his forearms, a pattern like river systems viewed from above. Twin blades at his back. A length of living chain at his hip that rested there rather than being attached.

He arrived at Nicholas's door and knocked. "Shadowrider?" he said when Alea opened it. "Inside," she said, because she had been expecting this, or something like it.

Valyren came in. Nicholas sized him up across the kitchen table. Valyren sized him up in return without apology. "I heard about the ward," Valyren said. "About the fifth anchor going active." "Word travels." "To people who are listening for it, yes." He sat down at the table without being invited -- confident rather than rude. "You are going to the Deepreach." "Eventually." "I am going with you."

Nicholas looked at him. "Why?" he said.

"Because the Earth Tower has been inactive for forty years and something in the Deepreach is using that to press against the ward, and I have been looking for something worth going toward for two years and this is it." He said it simply, without drama. "Also because you are going to need someone who can fight what is

in there. No offense to the shadow-air warlock -- but shadow-air warlocks need someone at their left flank."

"I do not know you."

"That is going to change."

Nicholas looked at Alexa. Alexa looked at Valyren with those deep grey eyes for a long moment and then walked over and sniffed the back of his hand. Then she returned to her spot by the window. Not disapproval. Not yet approval. Provisional. "All right," Nicholas said. "For now." Valyren smiled. It was an unexpectedly warm smile for a face that had been doing something much more controlled. "For now is enough," he said.

~ * ~

Adelaide and Dianne arrived the next day. They were not fighters -- this was clear from first look. Adelaide was calm in the way that a still body of water was calm: deep, not shallow. She moved with the careful precision of someone who had spent years healing people and understood that the difference between hurting and helping was almost always a matter of how much attention you paid.

Dianne carried a basket and smelled of bread and something warm that Nicholas could not name but that made the kitchen feel immediately more inhabited. She looked at the room, looked at the people, looked at Alexa, and said: "I am going to make tea. Does anyone object?" Nobody objected.

Over tea -- and it was very good tea, served with small warm inexplicably restorative pastries -- they explained themselves. Ward-healers and camp-keepers. Three different expeditions in the last five years. Never lost a companion to something preventable.

"We always travel together," Adelaide said. "Always," Dianne confirmed. "That is not a requirement for others to accommodate," Adelaide added quickly. "We understand. Together is fine," Nicholas said. Dianne patted his hand. "Good boy," she said. Valyren made a sound that was very close to a laugh.

~ * ~

Rominae arrived on a Tuesday and let herself in through the back wall of the kitchen, which did not move or open but through which she stepped as if the wall

were a curtain, arriving between one moment and the next.

Nicholas had the shadow up before she finished stepping through. She looked at the shadow in his hands with mildly evaluating eyes. "Dark magic witch," she said. "You have already been told about me. Or you will be soon. The timeline is a bit fluid from my perspective."

"Who are you?" Nicholas said.

"Rominae. I am here for the expedition." She looked around the kitchen, looked at Dianne's basket, looked at Alexa. "Is there tea?"

"There is always tea," Dianne said, entirely unbothered.

Rominae sat down. Nicholas lowered the shadow. "How did you know about the expedition?" he asked later. "I have known about it for approximately two years from a future that was no longer current but whose general shape remained accurate," she said. "Are you a seer?" "Souls can tell futures sometimes. I am not a seer. I am someone who has spent long enough with dark magic that certain things leak through." A pause. "Soul-sight. I can see what people fear most. Currently I am not looking." "What does currently mean?" "It means I have made a choice not to look unless I need to." A pause. "Some people find it less unsettling when they know someone could see something and is choosing not to." "Thank you for telling me," he said. "You are welcome," said Rominae.

~ * ~

Yulioh arrived the same afternoon as July, from different directions, and were mildly surprised to find each other at the door. Yulioh shook Nicholas's hand with the careful firmness of someone who understood that the quality of the grip communicated something. "I am the defensive anchor," he said. "Good," Nicholas said. "We needed one."

July was half-fae and had a quality of patience that reminded Nicholas of old trees. When she stepped into the garden she put her hand against the apple tree's bark for a moment and her face did something complex. "It is very old," she said. "The tree?" "Yes. And the ground." She looked west. "The Deepreach is very loud to me. Very old. Very much alive." She did not look afraid. She looked like someone who had known a thing for a long time and was finally standing in front of it. "Good," she said.

Ksu arrived that evening and was simply there, sitting cross-legged on the kitchen floor, drawing something on her own forearm with a small brush and a dark red ink that did not smell like regular ink. "The ink is alive," she said without looking up. "Everything I draw is alive. The fire burns. The stone stands." She held up her arm. "This is a speed-burst. I will need it for whatever is in the Deepreach." "What are you drawing it on your arm for if you are going to need it for the Deepreach?" Nicholas said. "Practice. Precision matters. A speed-burst drawn with one imprecise stroke will give you a speed-burst in the wrong direction."

CHAPTER IX

Laura and the Sound of War

Strategy is not what you do when things go wrong. Strategy is the structure that makes things go right -- the architecture behind the chaos.

-- From the Battle Compositions of Laura Veil

Laura arrived with an enormous case. Enormous -- genuinely enormous, a hard-sided case on wheels that she navigated through the front door with the ease of someone who had done it in much smaller spaces, tilting it at exactly the right angle to clear the doorframe without scratching it.

"Laura Veil," she said, extending her hand to Nicholas. "Sound Sovereign, Battle DJ, and your strategy officer. Do not argue with me about the last one. I have assessed the group and you need one and I am the most qualified."

Nicholas shook her hand. "I was not going to argue," he said. "Good." She was already opening the case.

The assembly she produced rose six inches from the table and floated in battle configuration: two directional emitters, a central unit, a microphone on an adjustable arm. All of it with a faint glow that was not electrical and was not quite magical but somewhere in between.

"Battle configuration," Laura said. "The emitters are directional. This amplifies power tenfold. I have damaged structural stone at full volume. Do not test it inside." "We will not test it inside," Nicholas agreed.

That evening, with the full group gathered in the kitchen, Laura spread a map on the table and began the briefing. "The Earth Tower is approximately seven miles in from the tree line. Based on fragmentary records and stated travel times of previous expeditions -- most of which did not reach the tower -- I estimate five to seven days of internal travel, depending on what we encounter."

"Seven miles in the Deepreach is not seven miles on a road," Valyren said.

"Correct." She looked around the table. "The records consistently describe the Deepreach as aware. Not intelligent in the way a person is intelligent. But responsive. It reads the group and it responds. The challenges we face are likely to be specific to us."

There was a silence around the table. "Specific how?" Adelaide said. "The records are not clear on that. One expedition recorded encountering a trial called the Fear Trial -- a sustained confrontation with each person's deepest fear, not metaphorically but apparently literally."

"I am telling you all of this so that there are no surprises," Laura said. "Or fewer surprises. For formation: Valyren -- left flank, front. Yulioh -- rear defensive. Adelaide and Dianne -- centre and protected. July -- environmental awareness and signals. Ksu -- pre-battle preparation. Rominae -- wild card, her own judgement. Nicholas and Alexa -- centre front. Me -- wherever the strategy requires."

She rolled up the map. "Any questions?" The kitchen was quiet. "No," said Valyren. "That was the best briefing I have attended." Laura put the map in its case. "I know," she said. "I give the best briefings. Get some sleep. We leave in four days."

Alexa, who had been sitting beside Laura's feet since Laura sat down, looked up at her with those grey-depth eyes. "She likes you," Ksu said. "I know," Laura said, not looking up. "Animals with good judgment always do."

CHAPTER X

The Mirror Arc

You cannot defeat a shadow self. You cannot bargain with it. You can only recognise it, acknowledge what it carries, and choose to carry it differently.

-- From the Trials of Ashenveil, Second Cycle

In the two days before their departure, the ancient well showed them things. It began with Nicholas. He went to the well alone, late in the evening, thinking about nothing more dramatic than filling the travel canisters Dianne had produced. He leaned over the well to lower the bucket. His reflection looked back at him. But his reflection's shadow was correct. It fell in the right direction. It moved exactly when he moved. It was perfect.

He stared at it. The reflection stared back, and then -- slowly, with careful intentionality -- it shook its head. Not: you are wrong. More like: you are missing something.

Nicholas stayed at the well for a long time. The thing he had been not-looking at for seventeen years was there in the surface, clear and close and patient. He was not his shadow. That was the thing he had not fully understood. He had the shadow, carried the shadow, was in some sense made of the shadow -- but he was not it. The pact was his. The power was his. The weight of the village's fear and Corvin's contempt and the years of careful aloneness -- those were things that had happened to him. They were not him. The reflection nodded once. Then it was just a reflection again. That night he slept without dreams for the first time in three weeks.

~ * ~

The others had their encounters with the well in the days that followed. Valyren came back from a solitary evening visit with a look on his face that was not his usual careful composure -- something older, something that had been under the composure for a while. He did not talk about what he saw. But in the morning he

was different -- present in a way he had been managed before.

Adelaide and Dianne went together. Adelaide said afterward: "I always thought my power was what I gave to people. The well showed me what I actually have. It is not the same thing." "No," Dianne said. "But it is better."

Rominae spent an hour at the well and came back with her arms crossed and an expression that Nicholas, with his empathic sense, understood was a kind of grief being carefully carried. He did not ask. She did not offer.

Laura went the next morning and was there for two hours and came back quieter than usual. Her rhythm was different afterward -- more grounded, more personal, less the master strategist and more the person behind the master strategist, who was also good and also complex and also afraid of certain things the way everyone was, and had decided to go toward them anyway.

They left the following dawn. Alea stood at the door of the house and watched them go. Nicholas looked back once. She raised one hand. He raised his. That was all that was needed.

CHAPTER XI

Into the Deepreach

The Deepreach does not have a door. It has a threshold. You cross it and the world behind you does not disappear -- but it becomes less certain.

-- Northern Reach Ranger Corps, entry log 449

They stood at the tree line at dawn. All of them. It was just the tree line, and the dark forest behind it, and the morning mist still sitting low at the ground, and the bird silence that extended from the Deepreach outward in a bubble of several hundred yards in every direction. Nicholas held the shadow compass flat in his palm. The needle pointed west, into the dark, unwavering. "All right," he said. They crossed the threshold.

The sound changed the moment they stepped under the canopy. Not quiet -- different. The bird silence stopped but a different set of sounds began: the ancient-creak of very old wood settling under its own weight, a subsonic presence that Nicholas felt in his chest rather than heard, the distant sound of water somewhere below the visible ground.

July put her hand against the nearest tree -- a vast, dark-barked thing whose lower branches were invisible in the dimness above. "It is saying hello," she said softly. "It remembers the last group that came through. It is assessing us." "What is it deciding?" Adelaide said. "Whether we are worth helping or worth testing. Possibly both."

Rominae was looking at the shadows between the trees. "The shadows here are inhabited. Not dangerously. Inhabited." "By what?" Yulioh said. "Things that belong here. They are curious about things that do not belong here. Currently: us."

Nicholas walked forward. The Deepreach received them.

The first day was navigation. The Deepreach did not have paths. There were spaces between trees where movement was possible and spaces where it was not, and the spaces shifted -- not while you were watching, but between attention

spans. You looked at a way forward and it was clear; you looked away and when you looked back the spacing had rotated forty-five degrees. July and Rominae navigated. Nicholas kept the shadow compass out. West. Always west. Unwavering.

On the second day, a wood-figure appeared between the trees -- human-shaped but twice human height, made of the same dark wood as the forest around them. It stood and watched them approach. Valyren had his blades out. "Wait," July said. She walked forward alone. She put her hand flat against the figure's chest and closed her eyes. After two minutes the figure stepped aside. "What did you tell it?" Valyren asked. "I told it what we were here for. It is a guardian. It was checking our intent." "And our intent passed?" "We are not here to take anything. We are here to restore something. That is a distinction it understands." They passed through.

That evening, making camp in a clearing that July said the forest had opened for them, Dianne produced food from her pack that was warm despite being carried all day, and they ate in the clearing and the shadows watched them and Alexa sat with her wings around Nicholas like a very soft very warm feathered fence.

"Are we being followed?" Adelaide asked.

"Yes," Rominae said. "Not hostilely."

"By what?"

"By the forest itself. It is curious about what we will do in the Fear Trial."

A silence. "It already knows about the trial?" Yulioh said. "It designed the trial," Rominae said. "It always knows which parts of itself are being used." She looked at the shadows between the trees. "Get some rest. The trial does not come on a schedule, but it comes when the group is sufficiently inside the forest for the forest to have read them adequately. We have perhaps two more days."

CHAPTER XII

The Ancient Pond Cocoon

Rebirth is not a second beginning. It is the recognition that the beginning was always this -- this moment, this choice, this willingness to become what you already are.

-- Written on the stone edge of the Pond of First Things, Deepreach Interior

On the fourth day, they found the pond. It was in a depression in the forest floor, lower than the surrounding ground by about three feet, accessible by a natural slope of moss-covered stone. The water was dark but clear -- the kind of dark that came from depth. Around the edges, organic growth had formed structures: upright forms of dark wood and something crystalline, arching over the water in the shape of half-opened hands.

July stopped at the edge. "The forest wants us to enter," she said. "Wants is a significant word for a forest," Rominae said. "Yes," July agreed. "I am using it deliberately."

Nicholas looked at the compass. For the first time since BunBun had given it to him, the needle had changed direction. It was pointing at the pond. "We go in," he said. Nobody argued.

The water was cold but not unpleasantly cold. It came up to their chests when they stood in the centre. Then the cocoons began. It started with Nicholas. Something rose from the pond's floor -- not visible, not physical. A warmth. A pressure. A gathering of what felt like attention from the oldest thing he had ever felt, older than the forest, older than the stone.

The warmth surrounded him. His shadow unwound from him and surrounded him in a shell, a cocoon of living shadow, and inside it he was in a darkness that was not frightening but was the most complete silence he had ever experienced. He breathed. The dark showed him things. Not visions -- feelings. The feeling of his power fully forward, undiminished, unsuppressed. The feeling of what he actually

was, stripped of the village's definitions, stripped of everything except the simple essential fact of himself. A warlock. A storm-caller. An anchor. An outcast only in the sense that outliers are outcast from averages -- not wrong, simply different from the centre of the distribution.

The cocoon dissolved. He was back in the pond. He felt different. Not changed in any visible way. More like someone who had been carrying something in the wrong way for a long time and had just learned the correct grip. The weight was the same. The carrying was better.

When all of them had come through, they stood on the bank and said nothing for a while. Valyren's process had lasted the longest and left him with his chain-veins fully lit and his face holding an expression that Nicholas thought he might be seeing for the first time. Alexa had not gone in. She had sat at the edge and watched, and when Nicholas emerged she put her head under his hand with a certainty that said: I felt it. I know what happened. Good.

"We should continue," Laura said, her voice slightly different than usual. Still precise, still strategic. But warmer. The person behind the strategy more present. "Yes," Nicholas said. He put the compass away and led them forward.

CHAPTER XIII

The Fear Trial

The Trial does not show you what you fear. It puts you inside it, until you find -- or cannot find -- what you are without the fear.

-- Recovered from the journal of an unnamed expedition, Year 821. The journal ends three pages later.

The Fear Trial arrived without announcement. They were on the sixth day when Nicholas stopped. The air changed. The subsonic presence deepened suddenly. The shadows between the trees moved differently. Everyone stopped. "It is beginning," Rominae said. She did not say what it was beginning. She did not need to.

The first thing that happened was that the group could no longer see each other. Not because they separated -- Nicholas could still feel them through his empathic sense. But he could not see them. The shadows had thickened between them until each person was in their own island of darkness, aware of the others but isolated from them. Nicholas was alone with his fear.

His fear arrived as a version of the village centre square. Empty except for a ring of Ashenveil's people, all of them watching. Elder Corvin in the centre. And behind Corvin, Alea. His mother, with her face doing something he had never seen it do: something raw and exhausted and aimed at him.

"I am tired of defending you," the fear-Alea said.

He knew it was not her. He knew it was the trial, the Deepreach using what it had found in him. It did not help as much as knowledge usually helped. "I know you are not her," he said. "But you believe I could be," the fear-Alea said. "You have believed it was possible since the first time you saw her tired. You have spent seventeen years being afraid that the moment she has had enough is coming."

"Yes," he said.

"And?"

He breathed. "And she has not had enough. She has never had enough. She chose to stand in the centre of the village on the day I was born and say: this is my son and his shadow is his, and you will have to go through me. She has said versions of that every day for seventeen years."

The fear-Alea was watching him. "You are afraid that will stop." "Yes." "You have been trying to minimise the amount of defending she needs to do so that she does not run out of energy for it." "Yes." "And?"

Another breath. "And I am not small enough to repay that with something she has to protect and never with something she can be proud of. That is what I am actually afraid of. Not that she will get tired. That she will spend her whole life defending something that never became worth defending."

The fear-Alea dissolved. The square dissolved. He was back in the Deepreach, alone, and then not alone -- Alexa against his leg, her head pushing up into his hand, her presence warm and absolutely certain. He sat on the forest floor and breathed.

It took three hours for everyone to come through. When it was over -- when the shadows thinned and the group became visible to each other again -- nobody spoke for a while. Laura spoke first. "We made it through. I want everyone to know that was harder than what I briefed and I apologize for underestimating it." "You briefed it accurately," Yulioh said. "It was just that accurate was not preparatory." "No," Laura agreed. "Are we all right?" One by one: yes. Yes. Yes.

Even Vlaedryn, who had joined them quietly on the second day of the journey, came through his trial last and looked stripped of something. Not devastated. Stripped of a particular armour. Nicholas looked at Valyren. Valyren looked back with the slight nod that meant: I see it too. Not now. Later. "All right," Nicholas said. "Rest. Two hours. Then we continue."

CHAPTER XIV

The Earth Tower

When the Earth Tower was built, the kingdom called it unnecessary. When the kingdom fell, the tower remained. When the tower fell silent, the village began to fade. The earth does not forget. The earth simply waits.

-- From the Lore-Wall inscription, Ashenveil, eastern gate

They found the Earth Tower on the seventh day at dawn. It appeared first as a quality in the air -- a density, a presence below the usual deep-forest presence, something that had been in the ground for centuries and had its own gravity. Then, as they pushed through the last barrier of closely-grown ancient wood, it appeared as a shape.

It was enormous. Not tall -- not a spire. Wide. Broad. Old in the way that boulders are old, in the way that mountains were old before they were mountains. The stone was dark grey-blue. Sea-stone. The same stone as the well in Ashenveil, the same stone as the pond. The tower was covered in roots -- not overgrown in neglect but wrapped deliberately. The roots held the tower. They were keeping it.

July stood at the base and looked up. "Is it intact?" Nicholas said. "Yes. The structure is complete. The roots have preserved everything. The tower has been sleeping, not dying." "Can you wake it?" "Not alone. It needs the anchors. You, specifically. The shadow-anchor."

He looked at the shadow compass. The needle was still -- not pointing anywhere. For the first time since BunBun had given it to him, it was simply still. "We are here," he said.

Rohmana arrived. She was there between one moment and the next -- simply becoming present at the base of the tower between the roots as if she had been there all along. "You came," she said to Nicholas. "You are surprised," he said. "Not surprised. Glad." She looked at the tower. "I have been here three times before. Each time the group that came was not complete enough. This is the first time all

five elements are present."

"What do we do?"

"Each of you who carries an anchor element puts your power into the tower simultaneously. The shadow goes in last -- it is the binding element. It is the one that completes the circuit." She looked at him with the particular quality she had -- a kind of temporal breadth, as if she could see the current moment from more angles than the usual one. "You will feel the ward from inside once the circuit is complete. You will feel what happens in the village."

They stood in a ring around the base of the tower. Nicholas looked at the group -- these people who had walked into the oldest forest in the world beside him, who had gone through the cocoon and the trial and the dark and the fear and come out the other side. He looked at Alexa. She was watching him with those grey-depth eyes. Her tail swept once: yes. Go.

"When you are ready," Rohmana said. Nicholas let his shadow reach out.

CHAPTER XV

The Tower Awakens

The circuit does not close with a sound. It closes with a silence -- the particular silence of something that has been open for a very long time suddenly becoming whole.

-- Rominae, in a letter written after the event

The activation did not take long but it lasted a long time. That is not a contradiction. What they experienced in the moments of activation was compressed into seconds of external time and extended into something longer than seconds of internal experience.

July's nature-light connected to the tower's root system. Rominae's dark magic found the tower's older lower channels. Yulioh's law energy anchored the circuit in structure. Laura's resonance-mapping read the tower's frequencies and matched them. Each one adding their element, the circuit building, the incomplete thing becoming less incomplete with every addition.

Nicholas went last. He let the shadow out -- all of it, fully, for the first time in his life. Not pressed down, not controlled, not minimised. All of it. The tower received it. The sea-stone lit from within -- not with light exactly, with resonance, with the vibration of an old instrument finally played. The roots moved in the ground beneath them, the root network activating, spreading outward from the tower in a pulse that Nicholas could feel moving through the earth like a long, slow sigh.

Outward. Toward Ashenveil. He felt the ward settle. All five points closing, the circuit completing, the structure that had been running on four anchors and collective exhaustion suddenly running on its own, self-sustaining, the geometry complete.

And he felt the village defenders receive what the tower sent them. He felt his mother -- Alea, south anchor -- and the earth power that flowed into her amplified, hybridised with the tower's essence, becoming something larger than

what she had carried before. He felt his grandmother Maria to the north, the water-tide power deepening. His grandmother Tamera to the east, the chain-momentum power acquiring something elemental and ancient. His grandfather Nichola, gravity anchors becoming root-anchors, earth and gravity fusing into something new and very old.

He felt them receive it and he felt them changed by it and he felt, across the distance, his mother's face turn toward the Deepreach, toward him, and he felt the feeling she had without seeing her face. Pride. Old, deep, no longer complicated by exhaustion. Simple pride. He stood at the base of the Earth Tower with his shadow fully extended and his eyes closed and let that feeling in.

~ * ~

They rested at the tower for a full day. Rohmana sat with each of them in turn and said things that Nicholas only partially overheard. She came to him last.

They sat at the base of the tower, between two of the largest holding roots, with the Deepreach around them. "Dimitreus," she said. "Yes," he said. "He has been watching since before the forcefield event. Since before you were born. The pact in your bloodline drew his attention decades ago. He has known about you. He has been patient."

"Why?"

"Because you are the only anchor that can threaten him. The shadow-element. Not because shadow beats void -- it does not, not directly. But because of what shadow is: proof of presence. You cannot have shadow without something that stands between light and darkness. Void has no shadow. Void negates presence. You are, to him, the one thing that is structurally opposed to what he is."

Nicholas thought about that. "He will try to change me," he said. "Not take me. Change me."

"Yes," she said, and looked at him with slight surprise. "That is exactly right. Taking is too direct. Changing is slower and more certain. There are already people working toward that. You have felt them."

He thought of Prolith. Of Vlaedryn. Of the dark thread he had seen thicken in the Fear Trial. "Yes," he said.

"I cannot tell you exactly what is coming. The futures branch too many ways from this point. What I can tell you is that the ward will hold now. You bought time. How you use the time is the remaining question." She looked at him. "I see you becoming something that does not have a name yet. I see the storm and the shadow finding their full form. I see a great deal of loss and a great deal of loyalty and a great deal of world between here and the end of the story." She paused. "I see Alexa -- always. That constant holds."

He looked down at Alexa, who was asleep against his side. "Good," he said.

Rohmana left before dawn. They began the return journey the next morning.

CHAPTER XVI

The Road Back

The return is never the same journey. You are not the same person. The road notices.

The Deepreach was different on the return. The ancient wood acknowledged them. The shadows did not press. The wood-figure guardians stepped aside without July needing to approach them. The return took three days instead of seven.

On the second day, Rominae came to walk beside him. "The enchanter was at the edge of your trial-space during the Fear Trial," she said. He stopped. "Prolith?" "He was observing from the boundary. Not inside it. But watching. I felt him."

"Why are you telling me?"

"Because I am the only other person in this group who knew he was there. And because you should not be managing information about a potential enchanter attack alone." She looked at him steadily. "Do not be alone if you can manage it. And tell me immediately if you smell burning roses again."

"I should have told someone the first time," he said. "Yes," she said. "But you are used to managing things alone. You will need to un-learn that."

He told Valyren that evening. Valyren listened and said nothing for a long moment. Then: "All right. We keep him in company. And we deal with the enchanter when he makes his move." "He may make it before we are ready," Nicholas said. "He may," Valyren agreed. "We prepare anyway."

He walked with Vlaedryn on the third day of the return. He had not sought it out -- had been avoiding the decision about when to have this conversation. But Vlaedryn came to walk beside him at the rear of the group and was quiet for a while, and the quality of the silence was different from the managed quiet that Vlaedryn usually maintained.

"You felt it," Vlaedryn said. "In the trial."

"The dark thread," Nicholas said. "Yes."

"I know what it is," Vlaedryn said. "I know where it came from. I have been carrying it for about a year." He paused. "I am managing it. I want you to know that."

"I know you are," Nicholas said. He could feel it -- the thread was there, thin and patient, but contained. Like a river that has been dammed. It had not grown in the Deepreach. "That does not mean you should manage it alone."

Vlaedryn was quiet. "No," he said finally. "It does not mean that."

CHAPTER XVII

What Valyren Said

The return is not the destination. The destination is what you become in the returning.

They reached Ashenveil on the fourth day. The village was different. Not visibly -- the same houses, the same lanes. But the quality of the air was different. The ward had a solidity to it now that it had not had before -- a fullness, like a drum with all its membrane intact.

People came out to meet them. People appeared at their doors as the group walked through, and the watching was different. Not the watching Nicholas had catalogued for seventeen years. Something else. Relief. Gratitude.

His mother was at their door. She had the earth-staff and the new power was visible in her -- not dramatically, not glowing, but present in the way she stood, the solidity of her contact with the ground. She stepped forward and put her arms around him, which she rarely did in public. "The ward held," he said into her shoulder. "I know," she said. "I felt it. All of it."

"All of it?"

"The trial. The tower. Your fear." She did not say it with judgment. She said it as information. "You were afraid I would run out. I want you to know -- Nicholas, I want you to know that fear has no foundation. It never had any foundation."

He held on for another moment. Then he stepped back. "I know," he said. "I understand that now." Alexa moved forward and pressed her head against Alea's hand. "Shadow-beast," Alea said softly. "Hello. Thank you for taking care of him." Alexa's tail swept once. You are welcome.

That evening, Valyren found Nicholas in the garden. He sat on the stone bench beside him and looked west at the Deepreach, which was silent and dark and not pressing, not testing, simply existing. After a while he said: "Blood Dominion. I should tell you what I found when I reached for your essence. Briefly, in the cocoon -- the pact energy was near enough that I felt it."

"What did you find?"

"Enormous patience," Valyren said. "And underneath it -- something that wants to storm. The patience is not weakness. It is what you use to hold the storm in check until the right moment." He paused. "Also: something that has been alone for a very long time. And is not, anymore."

Nicholas looked at the Deepreach. "No," he said. "Not anymore."

They sat in the garden until the moon was up and the ward hummed smooth and whole under their feet and Alexa slept between them with the absolute peace of a creature who had done what she came to do and was resting before the next thing.

CHAPTER XVIII

Burning Roses

The enchanter who changes his approach entirely is more dangerous than the enchanter who persists. Persistence is predictable. Change requires a new assessment.

-- Rominae, in a note to Nicholas, morning after

Three days after the return, Nicholas woke at two in the morning to the smell of burning roses. He was out of bed before he was fully conscious. Alexa was awake beside him -- had been awake before he was, her wings half-spread, her shadow-tipped fur lifted in the way it did before a fight.

"It is all right," he said quietly. She made a sound that was not agreement. "Where?" he said. She looked at the window. The western window.

He went to the window. Prolith was in the back garden, standing between the herb beds, the Deepreach behind him, the Whisperwand in his hand with its silver veins active. He looked up when Nicholas appeared at the window. Nicholas went downstairs. He made sure his shadow was fully engaged before he stepped outside -- present, solid, a defence rather than an offence.

"You came back from the Deepreach," Prolith said.

"Yes."

"The tower is active. The ward is complete." He tilted his head slightly. "You did that."

"We all did that."

"The shadow-anchor closed the circuit." He looked at Nicholas with those spiral grey eyes. "You are considerably more than when I first saw you."

"What do you want?" Nicholas said.

Prolith's head tilted again. The motion of someone deciding how to answer honestly. "I want to offer you something," he said. "Not a transaction. Not a

condition. Something given freely, because I have decided that freely-given things create a different kind of relationship than transactional ones."

Nicholas waited.

"The history of the pact in your bloodline," Prolith said. "The full history. The original compact. The names of the people who held it before you. What it was sealed against and why. You do not know this. I do."

Nicholas went very still. "Why would you give me that without condition?"

"Because you set the correct terms. Because you handled the sigil correctly. Because you are the most interesting thing I have encountered in thirty years and interesting things deserve to know what they are." He paused. "And because the threat that is coming -- the thing that your pact was sealed against -- is something you will face more effectively if you know its full history and why you specifically are the counterweight to it."

"Give it to me now," Nicholas said.

"Tomorrow," Prolith said. "With your group present. You said you would stop managing information alone. I am offering information. Manage it collectively."

A silence. Nicholas looked at him -- this strange, elegant, rose-scented person who appeared only when he was alone and who had just, apparently, made a decision to adjust his entire approach. "All right," he said. "Tomorrow. In the kitchen. With everyone present."

"Tomorrow," Prolith agreed. He turned toward the scrubland. "Sleep well," he said. "The next part of this is going to require you rested."

He went. Nicholas stood in the garden for a while, Alexa pressing warm and certain against his side, the ward humming under his feet, the Deepreach dark and quiet in the west. Then he went inside. He did not sleep, exactly. But he rested.

EPILOGUE

The Void Stirs

Every beginning has its watchers. Not all of them wish the beginning well.

In the space between worlds, Dimitreus assembled himself. This was a slow process and a deliberate one. He had been assembling himself for twenty years. What had entered the void after the second great conflict of the previous era had been something that was predominantly rage and power and the ruins of a plan that had been very close to succeeding and had not. What assembled itself now, two decades later, was something considerably more patient and considerably more dangerous.

The ward was complete. Five points, all active, the circuit closed. The shadow-anchor had taken the gap. He was not surprised. He had known this was one of the possible trajectories. The tower was active. The village was safe, for now, against the classes of threat he had been preparing. It was not safe against slower approaches.

He turned his attention to the threads he had placed in the group. Prolith had changed his approach -- the shadow-warlock was more perceptive than expected, had identified and confronted the sigil magic, had set terms that had to be respected. That approach required recalibration. More concerning: Prolith was now offering the warlock lineage history freely, which meant Prolith had decided that the warlock was worth investing in rather than managing. This was a significant development. Prolith was not predictable when he decided something was worth investing in.

Vlaedryn was more promising. The dark thread was stable -- it had not grown during the Deepreach time, which was slightly surprising. But stable was still present, and present was still useful. The warlock had not addressed it fully. He had acknowledged it. That was not the same thing.

He settled deeper into the patience. More power coming. More trials ahead. More growth and more capability between now and the end. Good. The more

powerful the shadow-warlock became, the more significant the eventual confrontation. And Dimitreus was building himself to match it, piece by piece, in the dark and the patient nothing, assembling something that was going to be large enough to meet what was coming.

He had time. He had always had time. Below him, in the real world, Nicholas Shadowrider stood in his garden in the evening light, the shadow compass in his hand, the needle still, his shadow falling behind him exactly as it should. Dimitreus observed this and was, in whatever way a void entity could be such a thing, satisfied. The piece was in place. The board was set. The next movement would begin when it was ready. And Dimitreus was always, above all else, ready to wait.

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Nicholas stood in his garden in the evening light. The ward hummed whole and complete under his feet. Alexa was at his side. The compass was in his pocket, its needle still.

His shadow fell behind him. Exactly as it should. It always would, now.

He was not finished. Not close to finished. He understood that the Earth Tower was a beginning, not an end. That Prolith was a complication that had been recalibrated but not resolved. That Vlaedryn was something he was going to have to face fully, eventually. That Dimitreus was in the void and was patient and would not stop being patient simply because the ward was whole. He understood all of that.

He stood in the evening garden and found that the weight was manageable. That was more than he had expected, three weeks ago. That was, for now, enough.

-- END OF VOLUME I --

NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER continues in:

Volume II: The Kingdom of Vieau

The road goes south -- to a kingdom built on solidarity,
and to companions not yet met.